

FEAR OF SELF; GIVING AND RECEIVING

Greetings, my dearest friends. May this evening prove helpful and strengthening once again for all of you and thus become the blessing that opens the further way on your path of self-realization. In order to realize that which you truly are, the fundamental prerequisite is fearlessness. Every kind of fear amounts, in the last analysis, to fear of self. For if there is no fear of your own innermost self, you could not possibly fear anything in life. Therefore you could not fear death either. Fear of self is the key. Before a human being is on any intensive path of self-confrontation, he does not know that he really fears only his own unknown depths. He projects this real fear onto any number of outer and other fears which he may or may not become aware of in the course of his life. For these projected and displaced fears may be denied and covered up as well. A person may, for example, fear any specific aspect of living. All the power of his hidden fear of self may converge and concentrate on a certain or a few specific fears. Or life as such may be feared and thus avoided, as the self is avoided to the degree it is feared. This general fear of life may further be projected onto a fear of death since they are really one and the same. He who fears the one must fear the other.

Only when this pathwork has become concentrated and awareness has sufficiently increased do you realize that you are really most afraid of yourself. You recognize this fear by the constraint with which you encounter yourself, by all the more or less obvious forms of resisting, by your terror of letting go your defenses and allowing the expression of the natural feelings. The degree of guardedness and of prohibition of spontaneity and naturalness is also not clear to begin with. These guards have become so much second nature that you do not even know that they are unnatural and that you could be quite different. Your inability to let involuntary forces guide you is a sign how much you distrust your innermost self.

In direct continuation of the last lecture, I wish to stress that anyone who constricts his natural soul movements does so because he is afraid of them, afraid of where they will lead him to and of what they may make him do. Anyone who is aware of this fear has made a substantial step toward his liberation, for without being aware of the fear of self, it cannot be overcome.

Fear of letting go means that the real self cannot manifest. It can only manifest as a spontaneous expression. Such spontaneity exists, for example, when knowledge manifests intuitively from within yourself, not through a learning process from outside. Only the person who does not fear himself, at least to some degree, can even register, let alone have the courage to acknowledge and follow through such intuitive, spontaneous manifestations of the inner being. The real artists and the great scientists make their important discoveries by this process. In this particular respect, they must be unafraid of their inner self. In other respects they may block it off too.

The manifestation of the real self is always a profoundly creative process, whether it applies to intuitive knowing or to the fullness and depth of feelings that make the personality vibrantly alive and joyous on all levels of his being.

Fear of not conforming to the environment is another aspect of the fear of self. For the inner reality may be at variance with the environment. The real values of the self may be different from the values of society. Only he who does not fear his inner self in this respect will refuse the ready-made values handed down to him. Outer values, whether right or wrong, still are shackles if they are not freely chosen.

One of the most important aspects of the fear of self is fear of pleasure. For the entity is created for the purpose of experiencing pleasure supreme, intense joy. The majority of individuals do not do so at all. The truly healthy and fulfilled individual, who functions as he is meant to function according to his inborn capacities, can completely surrender to the life force as it manifests in him with its pleasure currents. He will spontaneously express this powerful force; he will not fear and reject it. This will enliven his entire system with beautiful strength, energy, and delight.

He who is caught in guardedness and defensiveness and who is constantly watching over himself so that these forces cannot express themselves, numbs himself to a greater or lesser degree. He becomes dead. The prevalent manifestation in this world, today no more than at other times, is what may be called self-alienation or lack of aliveness or disconnectedness. It is a deadness that also brings in its wake a sense of emptiness and meaninglessness. It is deadness because the life force in its vibrant flow is willfully interrupted and prohibited by an overwatchful, denying attitude of the outer ego.

The average human being experiences some aliveness, at least at certain times, but it is so inhibited in comparison to what it could be that the full aliveness, even if there were a way to describe it in adequate words, would sound unbelievable. He does not even know how he could function and what his life could be like. He only has a vague longing, a vague sense that life could be different. And unfortunate is he who ascribes this longing to illusion, to lack of realism, and who then resigns himself to a half-dead life in the assumption that this is the way it must be. And fortunate is he who has the courage to acknowledge this longing, no matter how late in life, and then begins by allowing for the possibility that this longing is justified and means that much more can be had in life. And more can be had out of life if you become alive. And you can only become alive to the degree you overcome the fear of self.

Now let us consider this fear of self a little closer, my friends. Why is a human being afraid that if he is not guarded and constantly watchful with his will and his mind something dangerous might happen? This dangerous something would manifest from the spontaneous depth of his being. What is it? Fundamentally, there are two possibilities if we bring it to the simplest denominator. There is the possibility that something negative and destructive comes out. And there is the possibility that something creative, constructive, expanding, and pleasurable comes out. It is not true, as might offhand be believed, that only the former is feared. Although this is of course one very substantial reason for the constrictedness with which the individual prohibits the free flowing soul movements, the cosmic flow as it manifests in each created human being if it is unhampered, unmanipulated, uninterfered with. The destructive forces which the individual fears may vary in every conceivable degree of hate, hostility, resentments, rage, anger, cruelty. They exist in every

human being. They exist to the degree to which positive expressions have been prohibited -- first by the parents and the environment in the ignorant belief that these positive expressions are harmful and may lead to danger, and later by the individual himself. This is very important to understand, my friends. You are not prohibited, once you are an adult, by your past. You prohibit yourself when you continue to hold back those constructive forces which were originally forbidden by others.

Here, again, is one of those famous vicious circles that result from every error, every erroneous way instituted in human living. Because the positive forces are restricted, negative forces grow. Or to put it more accurately, the positive force is twisted, disturbed, converted, distorted, and thus becomes a negative one. It is not a different force that comes newly into existence, as you know. The rage is not a new emotion or energy current. It is of the same original substance that was love and can turn back into love if it is allowed to do so. In fact, it is easy for it to reconvert to its original way of manifestation, for this is the way it comes naturally. For example, once rage is admitted to exist and fully experienced in a way that is not destructive to anyone under the proper circumstances and in a way which at one and the same time lets one fully identify with the emotion and yet keep a sense of proportion about it -- does not reject the total personality because of it -- the rage will transform itself into warmth, pleasure feelings, love. This transformation may occur directly or indirectly via a number of other emotions such as sadness, self-pity, pain, healthy aggression and self-assertion, etc. All these energy currents must be experienced and owned up to. They must be allowed to exist at the moment, as long as they naturally exist. Then and then only will that which is unnatural and destructive reconvert itself.

Now let us go back to the vicious circle when a healthy procedure as outlined here is avoided. The greater the rage, the worse the fear of it becomes. Consequently, the more the individual guards himself. The more he is guarded, the less is it possible for him to be spontaneous and thus to allow the destructive emotion to reconvert to its original pleasure current.

As I said, not only the destructive forces are feared, but often love and pleasure are feared at least as much, if not even more so. They are feared because the child has been made to understand that they are wrong and dangerous. They are feared because they require this unguardedness that trusts the spontaneous inner nature. Love forces can remain alive only when the self is totally unafraid of itself. Giving up guardedness seems like annihilation because when guardedness is given up, something other than the watchful ego cooperates in the process of living. Without this cooperation, life becomes impoverished. But the acceptance of this cooperation hinges on meeting that which is feared. Thus in the vicious circle, the love forces are feared because they demand giving up the watchful, stilted, premeditating guards that make all spontaneity impossible. Thus frustration and emptiness increase anger and rage. Thus fear of self grows, and so on and so on.

This is the process in which people are caught who are unable to make the decisive step to overcome the resistances in order to meet that which is feared within. This is the one thing most individuals wish to avoid like the plague. It does not suffice to acknowledge in a vague theoretical way the existence of some negative feelings. It does not suffice to make abstractions about them. They must truly be lived through and dynamically experienced. This is inevitable and necessary and constitutes the facing of the self we are always talking about. Once this is undertaken, it proves not as difficult or dangerous as first anticipated. In fact, the relief and liberation, the coming to life is so real and wonderful that the hesitation seems foolish in retrospect. He who can bring himself to

make this step is blessed indeed, for life begins to open up only then. It is necessary to let go and let come out what is there, whatever the feeling may be.

I emphasize again, to avoid all possible misunderstanding, this does not mean acting it out in one's pent up anger, which only comes back to the self in retaliation. What is meant is that these emotions must be felt and expressed in circumstances and under therapeutic supervision where they can cause no harm. In fact, the more the destructive feelings are acknowledged and the responsibility for them assumed, the less will the person be driven, against his will and intention, to act them out in his environment. Such acting out is then excused by finding "reasons." Or else, the person is unaware of how much more strongly he feels in a situation than warranted, which inevitably affects others whether or not he admits it to himself. The acting out that happens daily in everyone's life may not take on violent forms, but it is all the more destructive in a devious and indirect way. This fact is not sufficiently appreciated and very much underestimated.

All this will be avoided when the full strength of a destructive feeling is directly expressed and lived through. The more totally this can be done, the quicker the transformation into pleasure feelings will take place. What happens after this depends on the extent the person is able to experience pleasure feelings. This again depends on several factors, some of which we shall discuss.

Some of the foregoing is another reformulation that sheds a little more light on the process of fearing oneself. As long as fear of self exists, freedom and fulfillment of one's life are impossible, my friends, absolutely impossible. It is so much better to acknowledge this fear of self, to own up to it and say, "Here is where I am at this moment, I cannot really allow to let out whatever is in me, for whatever reason," than pushing it away and make believe you do not have this fear. This fear then makes itself known in indirect ways which you continue to rationalize.

From here, my friends, we go a step further and look at another topic that is directly connected with what I just said. It is very important to understand. It will give you a new slant on certain factors of the inner life of man. Psychology has postulated for some time, and quite correctly so, that a human being's unfulfilled needs to receive, create damaging conditions in his psyche. Much emphasis has been given to this factor. As the body becomes thwarted when its needs are not fulfilled and it is not given the proper substances, so does the human soul become thwarted when its needs are not fulfilled and it is not given the substances on which it can thrive -- love, affection, warmth, acceptance of its own individuality. Both soul and body require pleasure. Without it, the person becomes crippled, his growth stunted. The helpless child is dependent on receiving all its needs from others, from the outside world.

Far too little emphasis has been put on, and by far too little attention given to, the importance of giving out. The frustration resulting from not sufficiently receiving was overemphasized in the last decades, while the frustration of not sufficiently giving to was very much neglected. It was correctly postulated that he who did not receive enough in childhood would find it difficult to give of himself, but usually this is as far as it goes. The healing of damage from insufficient receiving can be much better accomplished when the individual realizes that he is not helpless about his past, that he contains forces whereby a new balance can be established, but this can be done only when he comprehends the far worse pain of frustration when he does not give out what he has.

This overemphasis of one psychological aspect has created a generation of self-pitying people who go around in life bemoaning the fact that they have been shortchanged, that they have not received sufficiently in their childhood, and that they have to continue as cripples. The ability to unfold and give forth always exists once it is contemplated, once it is taken into consideration. So much pain existing in man's inner life is the pain of withholding what one has to give, and much less that of not having sufficiently received in the past. This is quite easy to understand when you think about it in a dispassionate way. If more and more accumulates of any substance, of any force, of anything, this overabundance must create more tension. The overabundance exists, my friends, whether you know it or not, whether you constrict it and hold it back in your fear, or not. Therefore many of you are pained at least as much as a result of not allowing yourself to give forth whatever it is you bemoan and wish to receive.

The energy flow of these soul movements is a continuum. They are an ongoing process. In this ongoing process, you must cooperate, in order to be healthy and fulfilled, by allowing this process to continue in a functional way. By functional, I mean according to the laws of life which prescribe that the positive forces be given on to others and that you receive from others what they let flow into you.

Religion has emphasized the aspect of giving. It has preached for a long time that giving love is more blessed than receiving it. It constantly stresses, in one form or another, the importance of loving -- that is, of giving love, of giving mercy, understanding, etc. But there the distortion occurred in a different sense. There, the distortion was and often still is that love appeared as a command, a pious command that is sacrificial. The image formed itself that to love means to impoverish oneself. Loving assumed the connotation of being a self-sacrificing deprivation. If one does not suffer through loving and for the love of another by shortchanging oneself in some fashion, it is not considered love. The command of love became more of an abstraction and contained the threat of forcing upon the individual certain actions that went against his interests. To this day, many people's unconscious concept of love is exactly this. No wonder that man fears to love if it is represented as a pleasureless, sacrificial, and depriving act that impoverishes the self for the sake of being "good" and of pleasing a God or authority. No wonder love is rejected if the pleasurable feelings it causes in the body are denied and accused of being sinful. One must then fear love doubly. Either one gives in to its spontaneous manifestation, then it becomes "wicked," or one cuts out the very feeling that makes up its force, then it becomes an unpleasant duty.

Mankind fluctuates between these two extremes: to either remain the greedy, selfish child, demanding to receive exclusively and not in the least being disposed to giving out, or straining into the false concept of love as described. Since each of these two alternative proves undesirable, man usually changes back and forth although one element may be stronger.

Only when you look at yourself with great honesty and a great deal of close discernment will you find both these distortions within yourself. Now, how can healthy flow of giving and receiving be created when such concepts and faulty attitudes bar the way? The fear of self must exist in both instances. For the natural impulse or the natural spontaneous urge is to give out abundantly -- as abundantly and generously as all of nature does! This applies to the most outer and material as well as to the most subtle level. The greater this natural generous giving out is, the less masochistic, suffering, self-depriving the personality must be. The more the false giving by self-impoverishment and lack of self-assertion takes over, the less real generosity and spontaneous outflow can exist.

There are innumerable occasions in people's daily life in which they stand at a point of decision whether to retain the self or to give out. The issue itself may not be important, but the underlying attitude is. The question may be to hold on to one's old grudges, one's old separating ways that exclude others in resentment or censorship, or to allow a new spontaneous attitude to come forth from the depth of the self. The latter happens naturally, not by force. It sees new realities about the other person that make the holding of a grudge meaningless; it sees no shame or humiliation in giving up arrogant pride; it sees no "lack of character" in understanding and forgiving. Many such "little" incidents loosen up the block of withholding that causes more pain than any lack of receiving. From there, it becomes easier and more and more natural to allow feelings of warmth to flow out. But at one point, the self must make this choice: to remain in the old, excluding, restricting way, or to allow for a new strength from within and follow it. Needless to say, this point of decision must be noticed. It is never unconscious in the way of certain truly unconscious material. It is quite on the surface, only most people prefer to gloss over it and do not allow themselves to acknowledge this "tiny point of decision" about so many issues in daily living. When this point is acknowledged and truly faced up to, it may appear like a precipice. The new way may appear to be risky; the old, cold, separating way to be safe although you all know with your mind that this cannot be true, that it does not make sense. Giving yourself to this apparently new inner force of giving out seems like going with a great, unknown wave. You may even sense the joy and liberation of it, but it still, or perhaps even because of it, makes you fear its further implications. If you can let go and give up the destructive attitude, whatever it may be, no matter how covertly it manifests outwardly, you institute an entirely new way of inner living. It is the healing you have sought and hoped for. This is the way it exists -- no other way.

When you come to this point of observation, you will not be able to make this step immediately. You will dwell a while in this teetering position and observe quite clearly how you exclude yourself, how, by holding on, you restrict the cosmic forces within your soul and retain yourself by constricting the outgoing flow. When you observe yourself at this cusp, you become aware of the implications of both alternatives -- the old constricting way with all its rigid formulations and pat ways, as well as the new vistas that open up. When you observe yourself for some time at this cusp, at this point of decision, and then do not pressure yourself but simply observe in fullness and know what each way means, you will finally become capable of letting go of the old way that refuses life, love, feelings, happiness, unfoldment, giving forth of what you have to give. At this moment, you may not have the strong feelings yet, but you will have a new understanding that includes others.

This new way increases steadily, provided you do not stop the flow. The flowing movement is beautiful -- it cannot be adequately described. It contains a wonderfully working mechanism of self-regulation that can be utterly trusted. To the degree you let go and give up a self-centered, selfish, self-pitying, or self-destructive attitude, fear of self automatically and proportionately decreases. Something new begins to happen from within. The creative powers begin to work in their functional way.

Thus you will no longer be thwarted by yourself. You will no longer inflict frustration and therefore pain upon yourself because the immense pleasure of following this natural movement will fill your being. The pleasure of giving and receiving will become possible.

For you cannot receive either as long as you do not go this new way. You cannot possibly open yourself up for receiving when you remain in the old position of refusal and isolation. As long as you do not let go of the restriction, you not only make your outgiving impossible, but you make receiving equally impossible. A vessel that is closed cannot be filled any more than it can be emptied. When you hold yourself tight and guarded, you not only do not protect yourself from any danger, but you close yourself to all the healthy universal forces -- those that could and should stream out of you and that could and should stream into you.

This guardedness impoverishes and deprives. Thus the person inevitably becomes enraged. The average person finds himself in the preposterous predicament of holding himself tight and restricted, guarded and overwatchful, unable to be spontaneous, always determining with the mind and the will, never allowing the creative processes to manifest. Therefore he frustrates the tremendous need to be part of the creative process. He frustrates himself by withholding from himself the intense delight and pleasure of being in the flow of giving and receiving. It is not an esoteric, otherworldly pleasure, disconnected from the body. It must be physical pleasure as well. The ironical situation then is that he resents the world for not giving to him. The world wants to give to him -- and yet he can never see what is given him. He goes blindly through life resenting not being given -- he does not even know quite what. He resents those most who really want to give to him, and rejects their giving, thus depriving himself even more of that which wants to flow into him. This would help him to give out so as to become part of the creative process again. In other words, he disconnects himself from the cosmic, creative flow of giving and receiving, of the constant turnover, the constant movement that takes place in the life process.

Now, my friends, these words are not impractical philosophy, perhaps beautiful but not realizable in one's daily life. This is not true. These words are of the most practical reality, applicable any moment you choose to do so, any moment you can observe yourself at some "point of decision," as I stated. The truth of this applies to all levels of your being -- the physical, mental, emotional, and spiritual, that is, your total being. It is all one and the same.

The impoverishment man lives under is totally self-inflicted because he cannot face that "moment" I was speaking of in which he refuses that which is given to him and that which wants to flow out of him. The new outflow wants to do away once and for all with that tight, constricted, resenting, destructive, enraged, rigid place from which you do not want to budge. Anyone who can find this place in himself and observe himself on the cusp has the best of chances. His good will to heal, to become free, may make him reach for the inner strength and resources to make and follow through the decision of the new way. All fear of self will eventually vanish. The fear of the negativity in you will vanish as you express it under the proper circumstances. As this fear vanishes, the new fear can be tackled -- the fear of pleasure, the fear of happiness, the fear of fulfillment, the fear of being in the stream without constriction. You will then see that acclimatizing to happiness and pleasure is not as difficult as it first seems when you wish to give forth what is in you. It is only unbearable as long as you want to receive only and do not wish to give. He who is still hooked, consciously or unconsciously, on being in a receiving state must fear fulfillment and pleasure. Not being aware of his predicament in its total significance and ramifications, he then complains against the world for leaving him unfulfilled. These complaints and resentments may take as many forms as there are human personalities. And many are not even aware of making such a general complaint against life. This, too, may be rationalized. It is part of your pathwork to discover it within yourself, to discover how resentful you become and how you refuse to budge from the negative position

because you feel deprived. And you must feel deprived because you make giving out of your wealth impossible and are therefore afraid of and closed up to receive. Thus you are doubly frustrated. Your refusal to let go of the negativity, the refusal to give of yourself makes you unable to receive pleasure, delight, happiness -- often even material success which does not involve the emotions. The great joyousness you sense exists must remain unattainable to you. You cannot tolerate it, it frightens you precisely because you are stuck on that spot where you simply want to soak in from others. It cannot work that way. All emphasis to attain liberation and well-being must pay equal attention to the frustration of not giving forth and to that of not being able to receive.

My dearest friends, may these words open up the way for you that makes possible the transition you seek so ardently with one part of your nature but still deny to yourself with another part of your person. Perhaps they incite a spark in you so that you can see, and decide little by little to relinquish all that which bars the way to your destination. This destination is complete fulfillment and pleasure supreme.

Be blessed, be in peace, be in God.

For information to find and participate in Pathwork activities world wide, please write:

The Pathwork® Foundation
PO Box 6010
Charlottesville, VA 22906-6010, USA
Call: 1-800-PATHWORK, or
Visit: www.pathwork.org

The following notices are for your guidance in the use of the Pathwork® name and this lecture material.

Trademark/Service Mark

Pathwork® is a registered service mark owned by The Pathwork Foundation, and may not be used without the express written permission of the Foundation. The Foundation may, in its sole discretion, authorize use of the Pathwork® mark by other organizations or persons, such as affiliate organizations and chapters.

Copyright

The copyright of the Pathwork Guide material is the sole property of The Pathwork Foundation. This lecture may be reproduced, in compliance with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy, but the text may not be altered or abbreviated in any way, nor may the copyright, trademark, service mark, or any other notices be removed. Recipients may be charged the cost of reproduction and distribution only.

Any person or organization using The Pathwork Foundation service mark or copyrighted material is deemed to have agreed to comply with the Foundation Trademark, Service Mark and Copyright Policy. To obtain information or a copy of this policy, please contact the Foundation.